

A BIG DEAL
Former US President George W. Bush with PM Manmohan Singh in New Delhi, Mar. 2006

KALYAN CHAKRAVORTY

HIS PRIME MINISTERIAL RECORD

I could not help being saddened at the way the public mood turned negative towards the end of Manmohan Singh's second term. He had served for 10 years as PM: the longest continuous period anyone had held that position since Jawaharlal Nehru. The performance of his government in the first seven of its 10 years was outstanding. The economy clocked an average growth of 8.4 per cent in this period, the fastest growth rate ever. It was on his watch as PM that India moved from being a low-income developing country to the lower range of middle-income countries and came to be recognised as one of the fastest-growing emerging market economies in the world. India's private sector came to be perceived as a potentially strong engine of growth capable of developing a global footprint.

It was in his term that the absolute number of the poor in India declined and 138 million people were pulled out of poverty. Primary school enrolment became near-universal, though much more needed to be done to improve the quality of education. Life expectancy improved and India was declared polio-free in 2014—in earlier years, the country regularly had about 100,000 polio cases. And he succeeded in bringing an end to the nuclear apartheid that had excluded India from the privileges enjoyed by the other countries in the NSG [Nuclear Suppliers Group].

THE HISTORIC NUCLEAR DEAL

The real importance of the Indo-US nuclear deal which was signed in 2008 was that it paved the way for lifting a number of import restrictions to trade in nuclear materials like uranium fuel for our reactors that were in short supply and also opened the door to a much wider range of cooperation in defence from the US. Manmohan Singh's quiet leadership was the critical driving force that made the nuclear agreement a success. He put together a team of key players and got them to cooperate and be part of the consensus that evolved.

Leading from the front was particularly important because many in the Congress party were ambivalent about the deal. They worried about the political consequences of seeming to get too close to the US, because they feared loss of support from the Left and were also concerned that closeness to the US would alienate Muslim voters. At critical points, the PM had to mobilise political support from outside the party, such as from Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam who spoke to Mulayam Singh of the Samajwadi Party to support the government. The PM was able to navigate the choppy political waters with skill and patience and keep his party on board. He certainly could not have achieved this without the support of Sonia Gandhi, who was fully aware of the party's ambivalence.

At the White House, Bush paid Manmohan a charming compliment: "I cannot think of anyone else I would rather meet at a time of crisis. You have a calming effect on people"

For Manmohan, leading from the front was important because many in the Congress were ambivalent about the nuclear deal

The PM's excellent personal rapport with President George W. Bush also helped. I saw a glimpse of Bush's personal regard for Dr Singh when he was in Washington DC on a working visit in September 2008. The Troubled Asset Relief Program (TARP), a key US Treasury initiative to deal with the financial crisis, was being piloted through a reluctant US Congress. President Bush had invited the PM and a few members of his delegation to a small working lunch at the White House. Manmohan began by thanking the president for meeting us at a time when he was greatly preoccupied by the efforts to persuade Congress to approve TARP. Bush paid him a charming compliment: 'Mr Prime Minister, I cannot think of anyone else I would rather meet at a time of crisis. You have a very calming effect on people!' I thought it was a very perceptive remark.